

The American Dream

From the end of World War II in 1945 to the early 1960s, America's dream of "life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness," as stated in the 1776 Declaration of Independence, was lived out by the majority. It was a time of wealth, peace, and unity, though not without its downsides.

BEFORE

During World War II many marginalized sectors were thrust into central roles, only to be sidelined again when the war ended.



ROSIE THE RIVETER

WOMEN AND THE WAR

Women played a crucial role in the US victory in World War II << 392–405. They served in the auxiliary army and navy services, and also the air force, flying new aircraft from factories to military bases or repairing those damaged in conflict. Many

women moved from low-paid administrative or catering jobs into better-paid munitions or engineering work, but were rarely paid as much as men earned. Most women in industry lost their jobs when men returned from the war in 1945.

SEGREGATION

Segregation remained legal in the United States until well after World War II, despite the US having fought against the Nazis, who held an explicitly racist ideology. President Truman desegregated the armed services in 1948, prohibited segregation on interstate travel, and outlawed discrimination by employers and unions. However, the reality for African-Americans was still a life as a second-class citizen 432–35 >>.

America emerged from World War II as the richest and most powerful nation on Earth. The only one of the wartime Allies not to be occupied or bombed, its industry—supplying its own military needs as well as some of those of Britain and the USSR—had provided full employment to its workforce and ended the Great Depression (see pp.384–85) of the 1930s. This economic boom continued in peacetime. National output doubled between 1946 and 1956, doubling again by 1970. Most personal incomes nearly tripled between 1940 and 1955.

The new middle class

This buoyant economy created a new middle class that made up 60 percent of families, who spent their money on consumer goods. Some 83 percent of American homes had a television by 1958, and two-car families doubled from 1951 to 1958. The US had 6 percent of the world's population (150 million in 1950), consumed one-third of the world's goods and services, and made two-thirds of manufactured goods.

Compared to the starch-rich and relatively expensive diet of their forebears in 1900, food was affordable and varied. The average American in the 1950s had a choice of green vegetables, frozen goods, fresh meat, and fast food. Consumption of hot dogs increased from 750 million in 1950 to 2 billion a decade later. As a result of an improved diet, children were on

Consumer Society

After World War II, Americans viewed consumption as a patriotic activity that helped aid economic recovery. The most sought-after items included refrigerators, cars, televisions, washing machines, toasters, and vacuum cleaners—all items that would modernize their lives.

average two or three inches taller in 1950 than they were in 1900, women could expect to live to 71 instead of 51, and men to 65 rather than 48.

The flight to the suburbs

One urgent need for this new class was decent housing. Inaugurated for the second time as president in 1937, Franklin Roosevelt saw "one-third of a nation ill-housed, ill-clad, ill-nourished." The postwar economy provided food and clothes, but good housing was still in short supply. A rising birthrate was met with a falling number of new home starts. Millions of Americans lived in cramped or inadequate housing.

One answer came from pioneer Bill Levitt, who won a contract in 1941 to build 1,600 row houses for shipyard workers in Norfolk, Virginia. Frustrated by union rules and having to organize numerous skilled workers to build and equip a single house, he divided the building process into 27 separate steps, training 27 teams of workers to carry out each one. The fastest workers earned the most pay. It was the principle of the production line. After the war, Levitt applied the same

Pontiac Chieftain

The American dream and the open road came together in stylish automobiles like the soft-top Pontiac Chieftain. Gas was cheap, and young people had diners, shopping malls, and drive-in movies at their disposal. Cars such as the Pontiac and the Cadillac became status symbols of the new wealth and freedom that Americans enjoyed during the 1950s.

